

WEEK 23

SUNDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Am. 7: 1 – 17*

The visions of the ruin of Israel.

From the prophet Amos.

Thus the Lord GOD showed me: behold, he was forming locusts in the beginning of the shooting up of the latter growth; and lo, it was the latter growth after the king's mowing. When they had finished eating the grass of the land, I said, "O Lord GOD, forgive, I beseech you! How can Jacob stand? He is so small!" The LORD repented concerning this; "It shall not be," said the LORD.

Thus the Lord GOD showed me: behold, the Lord GOD was calling for a judgement by fire, and it devoured the great deep and was eating up the land. Then I said, "O Lord GOD, cease, I beseech you! How can Jacob stand? He is so small!" The LORD repented concerning this; "This also shall not be," said the Lord GOD.

He showed me: behold, the Lord was standing beside a wall built with a plumb line, with a plumb line in his hand. And the LORD said to me, "Amos, what do you see?" And I said, "A plumb line." Then the Lord said, "Behold, I am setting a plumb line in the midst of my people Israel; I will never again pass by them; the high places of Isaac shall be made desolate, and the sanctuaries of Israel shall be laid waste, and I will rise against the house of Jerobo'am with the sword."

Then Amazi'ah the priest of Bethel sent to Jerobo'am king of Israel, saying, "Amos has conspired against you in the midst of the house of Israel; the land is not able to bear all his words. For thus Amos has said, 'Jerobo'am shall die by the sword, and Israel must go into exile away from his land.'" And Amazi'ah said to Amos, "O seer, go, flee away to the land of Judah, and eat bread there, and prophesy there; but never again prophesy at Bethel, for it is the king's sanctuary, and it is a temple of the kingdom."

Then Amos answered Amazi'ah, "I am no prophet, nor a prophet's son; but I am a herdsman, and a dresser of sycamore trees, and the LORD took me from following the flock, and the LORD said to me, 'Go, prophesy to my

people Israel.' "Now therefore hear the word of the LORD. You say, 'Do not prophesy against Israel, and do not preach against the house of Isaac.'

Therefore thus says the LORD: 'Your wife shall be a harlot in the city, and your sons and your daughters shall fall by the sword, and your land shall be parcelled out by line; you yourself shall die in an unclean land, and Israel shall surely go into exile away from its land.'"

Responsorial. *Cfr. Am. 3: 7, 8; 7: 15*

R: The Lord does not do anything without having revealed his counsel to his servants the prophets: * God has spoken: who cannot prophesy?

V: The Lord took me while I was following the flock, and he said to me: Go prophesy to my people.

R: God has spoken: who cannot prophesy?

Second Reading. *Book 6*

Adore God through the true holiness of works and of the conscience.

From the "Books of the Stromata" of Clement of Alexandria

He who journeys towards the Lord in love, even if his dwelling is still visible here on earth, does not remove himself from the earthly life, but detaches his soul from the passions. He lives, but he has crucified his greed and does not dispose anymore of his body to which he permits only the strict necessities, in order not to allow it the occasion for its ruin.

How can he who does not lie in evil still have need of strength, since he is almost not anymore down here, but is totally with him whom he loves? How can he resort to temperance if he does not have anymore need of it? In fact such greed that calls for temperance in order to be dominated, does not belong to the one who is pure, but to him who is still agitated by the anxiety of the soul. One resorts to strength then because of fear and timidity. It is in fact unbecoming that the friend of God, predestined before the constitution of the world to be elevated to the sublime adoption of sons, should be subjected to the passions and fears, all occupied in dominating the anxieties of the soul. You would in fact dare to say: as one is predestined on the basis of the works that he will accomplish and the effects that follow these works, so also he himself in a certain sense would have predestined for himself he who has loved him, through the knowledge that he has received. Nor does the knowledge of the future come through uncertain hypothesis as the major

part of men surmise, but through knowledge of faith received as something certain which for the others is uncertain and obscure: and he who is to come is already present through charity. He has in fact believed, through prophecy and through experience, in the God who does not lie; therefore he possesses that which he has believed and obtains the promise; since he who has promised is worthy of faith being the truth, he receives certainly through the knowledge the end of the promise. He in fact who knows that the state in which he finds himself gives him the certain understanding of the future things, goes to meet the future with love.

Therefore he will certainly not follow the things that are down here, convinced that he has to obtain those realities that are the true goods; he will desire rather to keep that faith that repays fully his desire. Moreover he desires that the greater number of his brothers that is possible will become similar to him, to the glory of God, which is realised through the same knowledge. He in fact who fully conforms himself to the Saviour is an instrument of salvation for the others, from the moment that the human nature has to reach and reproduce his image obeying to his commandments without deviating, this is to adore God, through the true holiness of the works and of knowledge.

Responsorial. *Mic. 6: 8; Deut. 10: 14, 12*

R: Man, you have been taught that which is good and that which the Lord asks of you * practise justice, love piety, walk humbly with your God.

V: To the Lord your God belongs the heavens, the heavens of heavens, the earth and all that it contains: and now what does the Lord your God ask you?

R: Practise justice, love piety, walk humbly with your God.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *2 Pt. 1: 1 – 11*

Faithfulness to the Christian vocation.

From the Second Letter of St. Peter, apostle.

Simon Peter, a servant and apostle of Jesus Christ, To those who have obtained a faith of equal standing with ours in the righteousness of our God

and Saviour Jesus Christ: May grace and peace be multiplied to you in the knowledge of God and of Jesus our Lord.

His divine power has granted to us all things that pertain to life and godliness, through the knowledge of him who called us to his own glory and excellence, by which he has granted to us his precious and very great promises, that through these you may escape from the corruption that is in the world because of passion, and become partakers of the divine nature.

For this very reason make every effort to supplement your faith with virtue, and virtue with knowledge, and knowledge with self-control, and self-control with steadfastness, and steadfastness with godliness, and godliness with brotherly affection, and brotherly affection with love. For if these things are yours and abound, they keep you from being ineffective or unfruitful in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. For whoever lacks these things is blind and short-sighted and has forgotten that he was cleansed from his old sins. Therefore, brethren, be the more zealous to confirm your call and election, for if you do this you will never fall; so there will be richly provided for you an entrance into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ.

Responsorial. *Cfr. 2 Pet. 1: 3, 4; Gal. 3: 27*

R: The Lord has called you with his glory and power, he has given you the greatest and most precious gifts that have been promised, * so that you may become participants of the divine nature.

V: All those of you who have been baptised in Christ, have been clothed in Christ,

R: so that you may become participants of the divine nature.

Second Reading. *Disc. 92: 1, 2, 3.*

As is the performance, so is the compensation.

From the “Discourses” of St. Leo the Great, pope.

The Lord says: ‘Unless your righteousness exceeds that of the scribes and Pharisees, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven.’ But how will righteousness be abundant unless ‘mercy surpasses judgement’?

What is more right, what is more fitting, than that the creature made in the image and likeness of God should imitate his creator who brought about the restoration and sanctification of believers by the forgiveness of sins. Thus

the severity of the sentence was taken away, all punishment was brought to an end, the guilty man was restored to innocence, and the end of sins became the source of virtues.

This is the way in which Christian righteousness can exceed that of the scribes and Pharisees, not by cancelling the law but by confuting fleshly understanding. That is why the Lord said, when he put before the disciples the right way of fasting: ‘When you fast, do not look dismal like the hypocrites. They disfigure their faces that men may see their fasting. Truly, I say to you, they have their reward.’ This reward consists only of praise from men. Out of lust for this an outward show of righteousness is common, and where there is no respect for conscience a lying reputation is sought. Thus sin, which condemns itself by concealment, delights in lying public approval.

The man who loves God thinks it enough to please him whom he loves, for no greater reward can be sought than that love itself. Love comes from God in such a way that God himself is love. The pure religious soul delights in being so filled with God that it seeks pleasure in nothing beyond him. It is a very true saying of our Lord that ‘Where your treasure is, there will your heart be also.’ A man’s treasure consists in the harvest of his fruits and the produce of his labours. Whatever a man sows, that will he also reap, and a man’s rewards are in accordance with his works. The longings of a man’s heart are directed to what he finds pleasure in enjoying.

However, there are many sorts of riches, and many materials for enjoyment, and so each man’s treasure is the result of his desire. If it comes from a longing for earthly things, it does not make men blessed by enjoyment of them, but wretched.

On the other hand those whose minds are set on things that are above, not on things that are on the earth, and whose minds are intent on eternal rather than transitory things, these have imperishable treasures stored up in him of whom the prophet said: ‘Our treasure and our salvation have come

Responsorial. *Cfr. Gal. 6: 9-10, 7*

R: Let us not get tired of doing good; if we do not desist, in time we will harvest. * As long as we have the occasion, let us do good.

V: Each one will gather what he has sown.

R: As long as we have the occasion, let us do good.

YEAR A

Gospel. *Mt. 18: 15-20*

If he listens to you, you have won back your brother.

From the Gospel of St. Matthew.

“If your brother sins against you, go and tell him his fault, between you and him alone. If he listens to you, you have gained your brother. But if he does not listen, take one or two others along with you, that every word may be confirmed by the evidence of two or three witnesses. If he refuses to listen to them, tell it to the church; and if he refuses to listen even to the church, let him be to you as a Gentile and a tax collector. Truly, I say to you, whatever you bind on earth shall be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth shall be loosed in heaven. Again I say to you, if two of you agree on earth about anything they ask, it will be done for them by my Father in heaven. For where two or three are gathered in my name, there am I in the midst of them.”

Third Reading. *Disc. 129*

The determined number does not limit forgiveness, on the contrary it extends it.

From the “Discourses” of St. Peter Chrysologus, bishop.

Every time that the words of the Lord are explained to us, let your minds be attentive, your soul docile, so that the intellect may penetrate the secret of the divine science. We listen because the Lord has today begun like this: “Watch yourselves! If your brother does something wrong, reprove him and, if he is sorry, forgive him” (Lk. 17: 3). O man forgive, God commands you, forgive the sins. Know how to bear offences and forgive the sins committed against you. In this way you will not lose the mark of the divine power that is in you. All that you will not have pardoned another, you will have refused to yourself.

Reprove like a judge, but forgive like a brother; because when charity is joined to freedom, and freedom to charity, it casts out fear and comforts the brother: when he offends, he is agitated, is a prey to fear, is besides himself, he has lost all human sentiment. He who does not help him piously,

he who does not assist him patiently and does not heal him with forgiveness, in his turn is without wisdom, is sick, invalid, does not have a heart and demonstrates that he is incapable of goodness. If the brother is besides himself, attribute it to sickness. If you try to help him in a brotherly manner attributing that which he does to his agitation, you will not impute the fault to him and wisely you will attribute it to his infirmity; to the brother instead you will grant forgiveness. In this way his salvation will be for you a reason for honour and his forgiveness will gain for you the reward. “ If your brother does something wrong, reprove him; but if he repents, forgive him”. Forgive the one who sins, forgive the one who repents, so that, when you sin, the forgiveness will not be given to you gratuitously, but as a reward. The forgiveness, is always the cause of joy and is even more pleasing when it is due to us. He who forgiving first has assured for himself forgiveness before sinning, has already avoided the punishment, he has anticipated the judge and has fled the judgement.

“And if he sins against you seven times a day and seven times he says to you: I repent, you will forgive him” (Lk. 17: 4). Why limit with the law, reduce with the number and fix an end to that sin which mercy pushes so much and grace concedes? And if instead of seven he will sin eight times? Is it perhaps the number that overcomes grace? Can the calculation be contrasted with goodness? And can only one fault condemn to punishment he who has received forgiveness for the other seven sins? Certainly not. If he who has forgiven seven times is happy, even happier is the one who has forgiven seventy times seven. But Peter, having forgotten this command, interrogates the Lord: “How many times must I forgive my brother, if he sins against me? Up to seven times?” And Jesus: “Not up to seven times I tell you, but up to seventy times seven” (Mt. 18: 21-22). This prescribed number does not place a limit to forgiveness but extends it; and that which seems restricted by the boundaries of the precept, in reality is entrusted without limits to the free will; for which, if you forgive as much as you have been commanded, you will always be in obedience, and together you will have a reason to be rewarded.

And if the number seven multiplied in the course of the days, months and years accumulates all together the forgiveness obtained, calculate and judge where the Christian who listens to me can arrive if that same number is multiplied by seventy times seven. Then he will truly finish contracting

debts and credits, then every slavery will finally have an end and he will have a freedom without limits in the eternal field of the harvest of God.

Finally the true forgiveness will come when the same necessity to sin will cease, when all impurity having been removed, the world will finally be pure, when the death will be destroyed by the life, when the Christ will reign and the devil will fall into ruin. Pray brothers, so that the Lord may make the faith grow in us and that we may at last believe, see and possess all these goods.

Responsorial. *Mt. 18: 15; Pr. 28: 29*

R: If your brother does something wrong, * go and have it out with him alone, between you two selves; if he listens to you, you have won back your brother.

V: He who corrects another will find in the end greater favour than the one who has an adulterous tongue.

R: Go and have it out with him alone, between you two selves; if he listens to you, you have won back your brother,

YEAR B

Gospel. Mk. 7: 31-37

He makes the deaf hear and the dumb speak.

From the Gospel of St, Mark.

Then he returned from the region of Tyre, and went through Sidon to the Sea of Galilee, through the region of the Decap'olis. And they brought to him a man who was deaf and had an impediment in his speech; and they besought him to lay his hand upon him. And taking him aside from the multitude privately, he put his fingers into his ears, and he spat and touched his tongue; and looking up to heaven, he sighed, and said to him, "Eph'phatha," that is, "Be opened." And his ears were opened, his tongue was released, and he spoke plainly. And he charged them to tell no one; but the more he charged them, the more zealously they proclaimed it. And they were astonished beyond measure, saying, "He has done all things well; he even makes the deaf hear and the dumb speak."

Third Reading. *Hom. 1 Sun after Pent. 1, 9, 11, 12*

He has done everything well.

From the “Homilies” of St. Laurence of Brindisi, presbyter.

As the divine Mosaic Law narrating the work of the creation of the world says: “God saw all that he had done and behold it was very good” (Gen. 1: 31), so also the Gospel narrating the work of redemption and regeneration, says: “He has done all things well” (Mk. 7: 37). “Every good tree produces good fruit; a good tree cannot produce rotten fruit” (Mt. 7: 17, 18).

And as fire cannot give out anything other than heat and it is impossible for it to give out cold, as the sun can only give out light and cannot emit darkness, so also God cannot do anything other than good, being infinite goodness, the light itself, sun of immense splendour, fire of a heat without limit: “He has done all things well”.

Today therefore we must say with simplicity together with this holy crowd: “He has done all things well; he makes the deaf hear and the dumb speak” (Mk. 7: 37). But this multitude of people certainly spoke through the inspiration of the Holy Spirit, like Balaam’s ass.

In fact it is the Holy Spirit that says through the mouth of the crowd: “He has done all things well”, that is: he is the true God, who does everything well, since “he makes the deaf hear and the dumb speak”; something that only the divine power can do. But from one work they pass to all the others: he has done a miracle that only God can do, therefore he is God who “has done all things well, he makes the deaf hear and the dumb speak”, that is he is endowed with virtue and divine power.

“He has done all things well”. The Law says that God made all things “good” (Jn. 1: 31), the gospel instead that he did all things “well” (Mk. 7: 37): it is not the same thing to do good and to do things well. Many do good works, but not good, like the actions of the hypocrites who are good, but done with a wicked soul, with intentions that are perverse and not upright. God instead has done all his works good and well: “The Lord is just in all his ways, holy in all his works” (Ps. 144: 17).

“You have done everything with wisdom” (Ps. 103: 24), that is with infinite wisdom and in the best way; therefore they say: “He has done all things well”.

And if God has done all things well and good for us, knowing that our heart would delight in good things, I ask why do we also not try to fulfil kind and good actions, knowing that God is pleased with such works?

But if you were to ask me: what should we do to merit always the enjoyment of the divine goods? I would answer with only one word: that which the bride and a good wife does for her husband: for this in fact the Church is said to be the bride of Christ and of God (cfr. Ap. 21: 2-9); and then God will behave with us like the good husband towards his bride, whom he loves above all things. For this he says through the mouth of Hosea: “I will make you my bride in justice and right, in benevolence and in love, I will betroth you to myself in faithfulness and you will know the Lord” (Hos.2: 21-22). Thus, brothers, we will be happy even in this life, this world will be for us the earthly paradise, we will nourish ourselves like the Hebrews with the manna of heaven in the desert of this life if, following the example of Christ, we exert ourselves to do well every action of ours, in a way that it can be said of whatever thing that is done by us: “he has done all things well”. The observation that though we are good by nature because we are created in the image of God, we are however wicked because of our actions will fill us with shame: by nature we are similar to God, through wicked works we are similar to the devil.

Responsorial. *Ps. 99: 3; Ep. 2: 10*

R: Know that the Lord is God, * he made us and we belong to him.

V: We are God’s work of art, created in Christ Jesus to live the good life as from the beginning he had meant us to live it:

R: he made us and we belong to him.

YEAR C

Gospel. *Lk. 14: 25-33*

None of you can be my disciple unless he gives up all his possessions.

From the Gospel of St. Luke.

Now great multitudes accompanied him; and he turned and said to them, “If any one comes to me and does not hate his own father and mother and wife and children and brothers and sisters, yes, and even his own life,

he cannot be my disciple. Whoever does not bear his own cross and come after me, cannot be my disciple.

For which of you, desiring to build a tower, does not first sit down and count the cost, whether he has enough to complete it? Otherwise, when he has laid a foundation, and is not able to finish, all who see it begin to mock him, saying, 'This man began to build, and was not able to finish.' Or what king, going to encounter another king in war, will not sit down first and take counsel whether he is able with ten thousand to meet him who comes against him with twenty thousand? And if not, while the other is yet a great way off, he sends an embassy and asks terms of peace. So therefore, whoever of you does not renounce all that he has cannot be my disciple.

Third Reading. *Conv. 3 c. 6-7*

Conference of the three renunciations.

From the “Conversations” of John Cassian, abbot.

Now we must speak of the renunciations, which according to the traditions of the Fathers and as the authority of the sacred Scriptures affirms are three, and which each one of us must practice with great commitment.

With the first we despise all the riches and the material goods of the world. With the second we repudiate the past habits, vices and passions of the soul and of the flesh. The third consists in withdrawing our souls from all the present and visible things, in order to contemplate and desire only the future and invisible goods.

And all the three must be implemented contemporarily, as we read that the Lord orders Abraham saying to him: Come out of your land and from your kinsfolk and from the house of your father (cfr. Gen. 12: 1).

First he says: from your land, that is renounce to the goods of this world and to the earthly riches. In the second place: from your kinsfolk, renounce that is to the way of living, to the habits and to the vices of the past, that right from the birth cling to us as if they were analogous and consanguineous. In the third place: from the house of your father, that is withdraw the gaze from all remembrances of this world that you have in front of your eyes.

And coming out with the heart from this temporal and visible dwelling, let us turn our eyes and the mind to that dwelling in which we will dwell forever.

We will implement this if, living in the flesh but not according to the flesh we will begin to soldier for the Lord, confirming with the work and virtue those words of the blessed Apostle: “Our homeland is in heaven” (Phil. 3: 20).

For this reason it is not of much use to us to have undertaken with all the devotion of our faith the first renunciation, if we were not to fulfil also the second with the same commitment and with the same fervour.

And so, after this, we could add also to that the third renunciation through which, having come out of the paternal house, we turn the gaze of the soul to the heavenly goods.

We will deserve then to reach the true perfection of the third renunciation when our minds, not weakened by the temptations that come from the weight of the flesh but purified from every attack and earthly habit with a very wisely polished work, by the unceasing meditation of the divine Scriptures and by spiritual thoughts, will be transferred to the point that to the invisible world which, intent to the supreme reality of the spirit, will not notice anymore that it is enclosed in a fragile body and in a determinate place.

Responsorial. *Gal. 5: 16-17; 1 Pet. 2: 11*

R: Walk according to the Spirit and you will not be led to satisfy the desires of the flesh; * the flesh in fact has desires that are contrary to the Spirit and the Spirit has desires that are contrary to the flesh.

V: I urge you, my dear people, while you are visitors and pilgrims, to abstain from the selfish passions of the flesh that attack the soul;

R: the flesh in fact has desires that are contrary to the Spirit and the Spirit has desires that are contrary to the flesh.

MONDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Am. 8: 1 – 14*

Other visions.

From the prophet Amos.

Thus the Lord GOD showed me: Behold! a basket of summer fruit. And he said, “Amos, what do you see?” And I said, “A basket of summer fruit.” Then the LORD said to me, “The end has come upon my people Israel; I will never again pass by them. The songs of the temple shall become wailings in that day,” says the Lord GOD; “the dead bodies shall be many; in every place they shall be cast out in silence.”

Hear this, you who trample upon the needy, and bring the poor of the land to an end, saying, “When will the new moon be over, that we may sell grain? And the Sabbath, that we may offer wheat for sale, that we may make the ephah small and the shekel great, and deal deceitfully with false balances, that we may buy the poor for silver and the needy for a pair of sandals, and sell the refuse of the wheat?” The LORD has sworn by the pride of Jacob: “Surely I will never forget any of their deeds. Shall not the land tremble on this account, and every one mourn who dwells in it, and all of it rise like the Nile, and be tossed about and sink again, like the Nile of Egypt?”

“And on that day,” says the Lord GOD, “I will make the sun go down at noon, and darken the earth in broad daylight. I will turn your feasts into mourning, and all your songs into lamentation; I will bring sackcloth upon all loins, and baldness on every head; I will make it like the mourning for an only son, and the end of it like a bitter day.

“Behold, the days are coming,” says the Lord GOD, “when I will send a famine on the land; not a famine of bread, nor a thirst for water, but of hearing the words of the LORD. They shall wander from sea to sea, and from north to east; they shall run to and fro, to seek the word of the LORD, but they shall not find it.

“In that day the fair virgins and the young men shall faint for thirst. Those who swear by Ash'imah of Sama'ria, and say, ‘As your god lives, O

Dan,' and, 'As the way of Beer-sheba lives,' they shall fall, and never rise again."

Responsorial. *Am. 8: 11; Mt. 5: 6*

R: Behold the days will come in which I will send famine on the country, a famine not of bread, a drought not of water. * I will send the thirst of hearing the word of the Lord.

V: Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for justice, because they will be satisfied.

R: I will send the thirst of hearing the word of the Lord.

Second Reading. *Hom. 30*

The Lord gave those pastures to the believers.

From the "Homilies" of Chrysostom Latino, bishop.

"The Lord is my shepherd; there is nothing that I shall want" (Ps. 22: 1). See in what way he recommends the Church through the mouth of his children: since truly God leads them, they cannot fall nor make a mistake. This is our king, who governs our hearts and our bodies every day, who guards our internal and external senses and we lack nothing.

Perhaps some will say that he of whom the Lord is shepherd, and who does not lack anything, all the same is tried in the temporal things. What does not lacking anything mean, if not that the Lord offers an open ear to those who ask? He leads and does not deny anything. That which he has affirmed: "They will not lack anything" is a great reality. When you do not sin against God, he gives wisdom, prudence, temperance, strength and justice: and if these things are not lacking, what else does the miser search for? God himself pours out everything in these virtues: and he in whom God is all in all, will never be guilty.

"The Lord is my shepherd, I lack nothing; in meadows of green grass he lets me lie" (Ps. 22: 1-2). A great thing is these pastures. These banquets always satisfy and never fail. Do you want to know in what way God pastures those who wait for him, that is those who hope in him? The prophet says: "Behold the days will come in which I will send hunger over the land, not the hunger for bread, nor thirst for water, but of hearing the word of the Lord" (Am. 8: 11). When our soul reaches this land of the law

and the flowers of the covenant, it is restored, nourished, fed, enriched, exults in the simplicity of the heart; the soul having arrived at this place, progresses, rests, exults and glories.

This good shepherd, who offers his life for the sheep (cfr. Jn. 10: 14, 15) gives such pastures to the believers who hope in him and arrive there, where he makes the souls rest in security. “In green pastures he makes me rest, to tranquil waters he leads me, he reassures me” (Ps. 22: 2-3). Great thing is this water. It washes impurities, takes away the stains, refines that which is rough: “You have undressed yourselves of the old man with his actions and you have clothed yourselves with the new (Col. 3: 9- 10) created according to God” (Ep. 4: 24).

This water occupies the first place among the elements. But when this element receives the Holy Spirit, it becomes a sacrament: and it is not anymore water to drink, but water that sanctifies: it is not common water, but spiritual nourishment. Through this water he leads them out purified, he makes them perfect, illuminating them he fills them with the splendour of the grace: because “there where sin abounded” (Rm. 5: 20) grace was over abundant.

“You anoint my head with oil, my cup brims over” (Ps. 22: 5). Thanks be given to you, Lord Jesus, who has shown us this oil. We know that it is the oil of the consecration. Christ in fact is called the anointed, and the Christians are called so from this anointing. Hear then, which is this cup. It is that which was “in the hand of the Lord, full of drugged wine” (Ps. 74: 9); it is that with regard to which, in the moment of the passion, he cried out saying: “My Father, if it is possible, let this cup pass me by” (Mt. 26: 39). And since he gave us the example of obedience, continuing he added: “However not my will, but your will be done” (Mt. 26: 39). The Church drinks of this cup, the martyrs become intoxicated with it. But how splendid is this cup, you see this from the splendour that it diffuses in the entire world through the passion of the apostles and the martyrs.

Responsorial. *Ez. 34: 12, 13, 14; Jn. 10: 10*

R: I will gather my sheep from all the places where they have been scattered during the mist and darkness and I will lead them back into their own land; * I will lead them to good pastures.

V: I have come so that they may have life and that they may have it in abundance;

R: I will lead them to good pastures.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. 2 Pt. 1: 5 – 7, 12 – 21

The witness of the apostles and prophets.

From the Second Letter of St. Peter, apostle.

For this very reason make every effort to supplement your faith with virtue, and virtue with knowledge, and knowledge with self-control, and self-control with steadfastness, and steadfastness with godliness, and godliness with brotherly affection, and brotherly affection with love.

Therefore I intend always to remind you of these things, though you know them and are established in the truth that you have. I think it right, as long as I am in this body, to arouse you by way of reminder, since I know that the putting off of my body will be soon, as our Lord Jesus Christ showed me. And I will see to it that after my departure you may be able at any time to recall these things.

For we did not follow cleverly devised myths when we made known to you the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ, but we were eyewitnesses of his majesty. For when he received honour and glory from God the Father and the voice was borne to him by the Majestic Glory, “This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased,” we heard this voice borne from heaven, for we were with him on the holy mountain.

And we have the prophetic word made surer. You will do well to pay attention to this as to a lamp shining in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts. First of all you must understand this, that no prophecy of scripture is a matter of one's own interpretation, because no prophecy ever came by the impulse of man, but men moved by the Holy Spirit spoke from God.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Jn. 1: 14; 2 Pet. 1: 16, 18*

R: The Word became flesh, and came to live in the midst of us; * we have seen his glory, glory of the Only begotten Son of the Father.

V: We have been eyewitnesses of his greatness, while we were with him, on the holy mountain.

R: We have seen his glory, the glory of the Only begotten Son of the Father.

Second Reading. *Treatise 35: 8 – 9*

You will come to the source, you will see the same light.

From the “Treatise on John” of St. Augustine, bishop.

In comparison, indeed, with unbelievers, we Christians are even now light; as the apostle says, “For you were once darkness, but now light in the Lord: walk as children of light:” and he says elsewhere, “The night is far spent, the day is at hand: let us therefore cast away the works of darkness, and put on us the armour of light; let us walk honestly as in the day.” Yet that even the day in which we now are is still night, in comparison with the light of that to which we are to come, Listen to the Apostle Peter: he says that a voice came to the Lord Christ from the excellent glory, “You are my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased. This voice,” said he, “which came from heaven, we heard, when we were with Him on the holy mount.” But because we were not there, and have not then heard this voice from heaven, the same Peter says to us, “And we have a more sure word of prophecy.” You have not heard the voice come from heaven, but you have a more sure word of prophecy. For the Lord Jesus Christ, foreseeing that there would be certain wicked men who would calumniate His miracles, by attributing them to magical arts, sent prophets before Him. For, supposing He was a magician, and by magical arts caused that He should be worshipped after His death, was He then a magician before He was born? Hear the prophets, O man dead, and breeding the worms of calumny, hear the prophets: I read, hear them who came before the Lord. “We have,” says the Apostle Peter, “a more sure word of prophecy, to which you do well to give heed, as to a lamp in a dark place, until the day dawn, and the day-star arise in your hearts.” When, therefore, our Lord Jesus Christ shall come, and, as the

Apostle Paul also says, will bring to light the hidden things of darkness, and will make manifest the thoughts of the heart, that every man may have praise from God; then, in presence of such a day, lamps will not be needed: no prophet shall then be read to us, no book of an apostle shall be opened; we shall not require the witness of John, we shall not need the Gospel itself.

Accordingly all Scriptures shall be taken out of the way, — which, in the night of this world, were as lamps kindled for us that we might not remain in darkness, — when all these are taken away, that they may not shine as if we needed them, and the men of God, by whom these were ministered to us, shall themselves, together with us, behold that true and clear light. Well, what shall we see after these aids have been removed? Wherewith shall our mind be fed? Wherewith shall our gaze be delighted? Whence shall arise that joy which neither eye has seen, nor ear heard, nor has gone up into the heart of man? What shall we see? I beseech you, love with me, by believing run with me: let us long for our home above, let us pant for our home above, let us feel that we are strangers here. What shall we see then? Let the Gospel now tell us: “In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.” You shall come to the fountain from which a little dew has already besprinkled you: you shall see that very light, from which a ray was sent aslant and through many windings into your dark heart, in its purity, for the seeing and bearing of which you are being purified. John himself says, and this I cited yesterday: “Beloved, we are the sons of God; and it has not yet appeared what we shall be: we know that, when He shall appear, we shall be like Him, for we shall see Him even as He is.” I feel that your affections are being lifted up with me to the things that are above: but the body, which is corrupt, weighs down the soul; and, the earthly habitation depresses the mind while meditating many things. I am about to lay aside this book, and you too are going to depart, every man to his own house. It has been good for us to have been in the common light, good to have been glad therein, good to have rejoiced therein; but when we part from one another, let us not depart from Him.

Responsorial. *Ap. 22: 5, 4*

R: It will never be night again and they will not need lamplights or sunlight:
* because the Lord God will be shining on them, and they will reign forever and ever.

V: They will see him face to face and his name will be written on their foreheads;

R: because the Lord God will be shining on them, and they will reign forever and ever.

Gospel. *Lk. 6: 6 – 11*

They observed Him to see if He cured on the Sabbath.

From the Gospel of St. Luke.

On another Sabbath, when he entered the synagogue and taught, a man was there whose right hand was withered. And the scribes and the Pharisees watched him, to see whether he would heal on the Sabbath, so that they might find an accusation against him. But he knew their thoughts, and he said to the man who had the withered hand, "Come and stand here." And he rose and stood there.

And Jesus said to them, "I ask you, is it lawful on the Sabbath to do good or to do harm, to save life or to destroy it?" And he looked around on them all, and said to him, "Stretch out your hand." And he did so, and his hand was restored. But they were filled with fury and discussed with one another what they might do to Jesus.

TUESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading *Amos 9:1 – 15*

The salvation of the just.

I saw the LORD standing beside the altar, and he said: “Smite the capitals until the thresholds shake, and shatter them on the heads of all the people; and what are left of them I will slay with the sword; not one of them shall flee away, not one of them shall escape. “Though they dig into Sheol, from there shall my hand take them; though they climb up to heaven, from there I will bring them down. Though they hide themselves on the top of Carmel, from there I will search out and take them; and though they hide from my sight at the bottom of the sea, there I will command the serpent, and it shall bite them. And though they go into captivity before their enemies, there I will command the sword, and it shall slay them; and I will set my eyes upon them for evil and not for good.”

The Lord, GOD of hosts, he who touches the earth and it melts, and all who dwell in it mourn, and all of it rises like the Nile, and sinks again, like the Nile of Egypt; who builds his upper chambers in the heavens, and founds his vault upon the earth; who calls for the waters of the sea, and pours them out upon the surface of the earth -- the LORD is his name.

“Are you not like the Ethiopians to me, O people of Israel?” says the LORD. “Did I not bring up Israel from the land of Egypt, and the Philistines from Caphtor and the Syrians from Kir? Behold, the eyes of the Lord GOD are upon the sinful kingdom, and I will destroy it from the surface of the ground; except that I will not utterly destroy the house of Jacob”, says the LORD. “For lo, I will command, and shake the house of Israel among all the nations as one shakes with a sieve, but no pebble shall fall upon the earth. All the sinners of my people shall die by the sword, who say, ‘Evil shall not overtake or meet us’.

“In that day I will raise up the booth of David that is fallen and repair its breaches, and raise up its ruins, and rebuild it as in the days of old; that they may possess the remnant of Edom and all the nations who are called by my name”, says the LORD who does this. “Behold, the days are coming,” says the LORD, “when the ploughman shall overtake the reaper and the

treader of grapes him who sows the seed; the mountains shall drip sweet wine, and all the hills shall flow with it. I will restore the fortunes of my people Israel, and they shall rebuild the ruined cities and inhabit them; they shall plant vineyards and drink their wine, and they shall make gardens and eat their fruit. I will plant them upon their land, and they shall never again be plucked up out of the land which I have given them,” says the LORD your God.

Responsorial *Cf. Act 15:16, 17, 14-15*

R: I will return and I will rebuild the tent of David, says the Lord. * All the nations on whom my name has been invoked will search for me.

V: God has wanted to choose from among the pagans a people to consecrate them to his name, as it is written:

R: All the nations on whom my name has been invoked will search for me.

Second Reading *Hom. 1, 16*

We are the people of God

From the “Homilies” of St. Bede the Venerable, presbyter

We, dearest brothers, are the people of God, we who freed through the Red Sea have left behind the yoke of the Egyptian slavery, having received through the water of baptism the remission of sins which oppressed us. Through the anxieties of the present life, as in the dryness of the desert, we wait to enter as it has been promised to us into the heavenly homeland. But in the journey towards it we run the risk of failing because of thirst and spiritual hunger, if the gifts of our Saviour were not to fortify us and if the sacraments of his incarnation were not to renew us.

It is exactly he who is the manna that restores us so that we do not faint on the journey of this life; he himself is the rock that inebriates us with the spiritual gifts: struck with the wood of the cross, he made the drink of life gush out from his side for us. For which he says in the gospel: “I am the bread of life; he who comes to me will not be hungry anymore and he who believes in me will not be thirsty again” (Jn. 6: 35). And according to a succession of figures that correspond fairly well, at first the people are saved through the sea in order to reach mystically in this way the food of the manna and to the rock of the drink, because first the water of

regeneration purifies us, and then it leads us to participate at the sacred table where we communicate with the flesh and the blood of our Redeemer.

It is a useful thing to display more abundantly these realities relative to the mystery of the spiritual rock, from which the first shepherd of the Church takes his name, and on which the whole building of the Church itself remains motionless and unshakeable; from that rock the Holy Church is born and nourishes itself. The hearts of the listeners, in fact, are used to adhere more closely and with greater sweetness to the things prefigured in the past and then clarified with a new explanation in a spiritual sense, rather than that proposed for belief or for doing without any example of images, but only with a simple narration. Let us say in a way, dearest brothers, that always adhering to the bulwark of this rock we will not be shaken from the firmness of the faith either by the dismay for the aversion of the things that pass away, or from the allurements of the sweetness. At the present, ignoring the temporal delights, only the heavenly gifts of our Redeemer entice us; among the adversities of this life the hope of his vision consoles us uniquely.

Let us meditate attentively on the great example of the king and prophet David, who in the riches and in the many honours of the kingdom could not find any comfort for his soul until he, lifting the eyes of his mind to the supreme desire, remembered God and rejoiced.

And in order to deserve to reach his same vision, let us occupy ourselves with excluding from our minds and from our bodies the obstacles of vices that usually impede us. It is not possible to reach it if not by walking in uprightness, because his pure face is seen by the pure of heart: “Blessed are the pure of heart for they shall see God” (Mt. 5: 8).

He who has deigned to promise us this wants to grant it to us, Jesus Christ God and Lord, who lives and reigns with the Father in the unity of the Holy Spirit forever and ever. Amen.

Responsorial. *Jn. 10: 14; Ez. 34: 11, 13*

R: I am the good shepherd, * I know my sheep and my sheep know me.

V: Behold, I myself will go in search of my sheep and I will take care of them. I will take them back from the nations and I will pasture them.

R: I know my sheep and my sheep know me.

First Reading. *2 Pt. 2:1 – 9*

False teachers.

From the Second Letter of St. Peter, apostle.

But false prophets also arose among the people, just as there will be false teachers among you, who will secretly bring in destructive heresies, even denying the Master who bought them, bringing upon themselves swift destruction.

And many will follow their licentiousness, and because of them the way of truth will be reviled. And in their greed they will exploit you with false words; from of old their condemnation has not been idle, and their destruction has not been asleep. For if God did not spare the angels when they sinned, but cast them into hell and committed them to pits of nether gloom to be kept until the judgement; if he did not spare the ancient world, but preserved Noah, a herald of righteousness, with seven other persons, when he brought a flood upon the world of the ungodly; if by turning the cities of Sodom and Gomor'rah to ashes he condemned them to extinction and made them an example to those who were to be ungodly; and if he rescued righteous Lot, greatly distressed by the licentiousness of the wicked (for by what that righteous man saw and heard as he lived among them, he was vexed in his righteous soul day after day with their lawless deeds), then the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from trial, and to keep the unrighteous under punishment until the day of judgement.

Responsorial. *Mt. 7: 15; 24: 11, 24*

R: Be aware of false prophets, who come to you dressed as sheep, * but inside they are ravenous wolves.

V: Many false prophets will arise, and they will do portents, and they will deceive many;

R: but inside they are ravenous wolves.

Second Reading. *Disc. 37: 5 – 7*

Beginning of wisdom is the fear of the Lord.

From the “Discourses on the Song of Songs” of St. Bernard, abbot.

If we are obscured by the ignorance of God, how could we hope in him whom we do not know? If we are prisoners of the ignorance of ourselves, how could we be humble? We could believe in fact to be something, while we are nothing. And we know that neither the proud nor the wretches will have a part or communion with the destiny of the saints.

Consider therefore together with me with how much care and solicitude we must free ourselves from these two types of ignorance, the first of which is the origin of every sin, while the other is its fulfilment; in the same way that the two types of knowledge – of God and of oneself – produce respectively the beginning and the perfection of wisdom, that is one the fear of the Lord and the other charity.

In fact, as the “beginning of wisdom is the fear of the Lord” (Ps. 110: 10), so also “the beginning of all sins is the pride” (Sir. 10: 15 Vulg. Cfr. 10: 12, 13); and if the love of God is the perfection of wisdom, the desperation is the consummation of every evil. So also, if from the knowledge of oneself the fear of the Lord rises in the heart and the love for God from the knowledge of God, from ignorance of oneself instead pride springs up and desperation from the ignorance of God.

The ignorance of oneself generates in us pride because, deceived by a blind and false mentality, we believe ourselves to be better than what we are. Pride consists exactly in this, here is the root of all sins: in believing oneself to be greater than one really is in front of God, than one really is in truth. Therefore, in so much as we humiliate ourselves, in so much as we repute ourselves inferior to that which we are, that is as according to how the Truth values us, we do not run any danger. But it is a very great injury to raise oneself even a little over oneself and to prefer oneself mentally to someone whom the Truth judges to be equal or superior to us. In order to give a concrete example, it is like when, having to pass through one door whose lintel is too low, you can lower yourself as much as you want without hurting yourself. But if you will rise up even an inch above the height of the door, you will bang against it and you will break your head. In the same way we must not fear any humiliation, no matter how great it is, but have a great fear and horror also of the smallest impulse of presumption.

Therefore let us not compare ourselves to those who are superior or inferior to us, let us not confront ourselves with anyone, not even with one single man. How do you know if he whom you consider as the most despicable of all, by a change operated by the power of the Most High, will

not become better than you and than the others or if he is not already really in God? Therefore the Lord wants that we choose not a mediocre place, nor the second last place and not even one of the last, but he says: Go and sit down in the last place” (Lk. 14: 10), in a way that only you are the last of all and you do not prefer yourself, in fact you do not dare to compare yourself to anyone.

Responsorial Cf. Ps 110:10; Wis 6:18; Sir 19:18

R: The beginning of wisdom is the fear of the Lord, wise are those who practise it; * the praise of the Lord is without end.

V: Love is the guardian of the law, because all of wisdom is in the fear of God.

R: The praise of the Lord is without end.

Gospel Lk 6:12 – 19

*He spent the night in prayer, then He chose twelve
To whom He gave the name apostles.*

In these days he went out to the mountain to pray; and all night he continued in prayer to God. And when it was day, he called his disciples, and chose from them twelve, whom he named apostles; Simon, whom he named Peter, and Andrew his brother, and James and John, and Philip, and Bartholomew, and Matthew, and Thomas, and James the son of Alphaeus, and Simon who was called the Zealot, and Judas the son of James, and Judas Iscariot, who became a traitor.

And he came down with them and stood on a level place, with a great crowd of his disciples and a great multitude of people from all Judea and Jerusalem and the seacoast of Tyre and Sidon, who came to hear him and to be healed of their diseases; and those who were troubled with unclean spirits were cured. And the entire crowd sought to touch him, for power came forth from him and healed them all.

WEDNESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Hos. 1:1 – 9; 3: 1 – 5*

The prophet is like a sign of the love of God for His people.

From the prophet Hosea.

The word of the LORD that came to Hose'a the son of Be-e'ri, in the days of Uzzi'ah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezeki'ah, kings of Judah, and in the days of Jerobo'am the son of Jo'ash, king of Israel.

When the LORD first spoke through Hose'a, the LORD said to Hose'a, "Go, take to yourself a wife of harlotry and have children of harlotry, for the land commits great harlotry by forsaking the LORD."

So he went and took Gomer the daughter of Dibla'im, and she conceived and bore him a son. And the LORD said to him, "Call his name Jezreel; for yet a little while, and I will punish the house of Jehu for the blood of Jezreel, and I will put an end to the kingdom of the house of Israel. And on that day, I will break the bow of Israel in the valley of Jezreel."

She conceived again and bore a daughter. And the LORD said to him, "Call her name Not pitied, for I will no more have pity on the house of Israel, to forgive them at all. But I will have pity on the house of Judah, and I will deliver them by the LORD their God; I will not deliver them by bow, nor by sword, nor by war, nor by horses, nor by horsemen."

When she had weaned Not pitied, she conceived and bore a son. And the LORD said, "Call his name Not my people, for you are not my people and I am not your God." And the LORD said to me, "Go again, love a woman who is beloved of a paramour and is an adulteress; even as the LORD loves the people of Israel, though they turn to other gods and love cakes of raisins."

So I bought her for fifteen shekels of silver and a homer and a lethech of barley. And I said to her, "You must dwell as mine for many days; you shall not play the harlot, or belong to another man; so will I also be to you." For the children of Israel shall dwell many days without king or prince, without sacrifice or pillar, without ephod or teraphim. Afterward the children of Israel shall return and seek the LORD their God, and David their

king; and they shall come in fear to the LORD and to his goodness in the latter days.

Responsorial. *Cfr. 1 Pet. 2: 9, 10; Rm. 9: 26*

R: You are the elected race, the royal priesthood. * Once you were not a people, now you are the people of God.

V: In the place where it was said: “You are not my people”, there, you have been called sons of the living God.

R: Once you were not a people, now you are the people of God.

Second Reading. *Treatise 10*

Love is strong as death.

From the “Treatise” of Baldwin of Canterbury, bishop.

Death is strong: it has the power to deprive us of the gift of life. Love is strong: it has the power to restore us to the exercise of a better life.

Death is strong, strong enough to despoil us of this body of ours. Love is strong, strong enough to rob death of its spoils and restore them to us.

Death is strong; for no man can resist it. Love is strong; for it can triumph over death, can blunt its sting, counter its onslaught and overrun its victory. A time will come when death will be trampled underfoot; when it will be said: ‘Death, where is your sting? Death, where is your attack?’

‘Love is strong as death,’ since Christ’s love is the death of death. For this reason he says: ‘Death, I shall be your death; hell, I shall grip you fast.’

The love, too, with which Christ is loved by us is itself strong as death, since it is a kind of death, being the extinction of our old life, the abolition of vice, and the putting aside of dead works.

This love of ours for Christ is a sort of return, though not equal to his love for us; and it is a copy, a likeness of his. For he first loved us, and by the example of love that he sets before us, he has become a seal by which we are moulded to his image – putting off the likeness of the earthly and bearing that of the heavenly, loving him as we are loved. In this he leaves us an example, that we may follow in his footsteps.

That is why he says: ‘Set me as a seal on your heart.’ As though to say: Love me, as I love you; have me in your mind, in your memory, in your desire; in your sighing, your groaning, your weeping. Remember,

man, in what state I fashioned you, how far I preferred you before the rest of creatures, the dignity with which I ennobled you; how I crowned you with glory and honour, made you a little less than the angels, and subjected all things under your feet. Remember not only the great things I did for you, but what harsh indignities I bore on your behalf; and see if you are not acting wickedly against me, if you do not love me. For who loves you as I love you? Who created you, if not I? Who redeemed you, if not I?

Lord, take away from me the heart of stone, a heart shrunken and uncircumcised – take it away and give me a new heart, a heart of flesh, a clean heart. You cleanse our heart and love the heart that is clean – possess my heart and dwell in it, both holding it and filling it. You surpass what is highest in me, and yet are within my inmost self! Pattern of beauty and seal of holiness, mould my heart in your likeness: mould my heart under your mercy, God of my heart and God my portion forever. Amen.

Responsorial. *Sg. Of Sgs. 8: 6-7; Jn. 15: 13*

R: Love is as strong as death. Its flame is a flame of fire, a flame from the Lord! * The great waters cannot quench love.

V: No one has a love that is greater than this: to give the life for his own enemies.

R: The great waters cannot quench love.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *2 Pt. 2: 9 – 22*

Denouncement of sins.

From the Second Letter of St. Peter, apostle.

Then the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from trial, and to keep the **unrighteous** under punishment until the Day of Judgement, and especially those **who indulge in the lust of defiling passion and despise authority**.

Bold and wilful, they are not afraid to revile the glorious ones, whereas angels, though greater in might and power, do not pronounce a reviling judgement upon them before the Lord. But these, like irrational animals, creatures of instinct, born to be caught and killed, reviling in matters of

which they are ignorant, will be destroyed in the same destruction with them, suffering wrong for their wrongdoing. They count it pleasure to revel in the daytime. They are **blots and blemishes**, revelling in their dissipation, carousing with you. They have eyes full of adultery, insatiable for sin. They entice unsteady souls. They have hearts trained in greed. Accursed children! Forsaking the right way they have gone astray; they have followed the way of Balaam, the son of Be'or, who loved gain from wrongdoing, but was rebuked for his own transgression; a dumb ass spoke with human voice and restrained the prophet's madness.

These are waterless springs and mists driven by a storm; for them the nether gloom of darkness has been reserved. For, uttering loud boasts of folly, they entice with licentious passions of the flesh men who have barely escaped from those who live in error. They promise them freedom, but they themselves are **slaves of corruption**; for whatever overcomes a man, to that he is enslaved.

For if, **after they have escaped the defilements of the world through the knowledge of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, they are again entangled in them and overpowered, the last state has become worse for them than the first.** For it would have been better for them never to have known the way of righteousness than after knowing it to turn back from the holy commandment delivered to them. It has happened to them according to the true proverb, **the dog turns back to his own vomit**, and the sow is washed only to wallow in the mire.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Phil 4: 8, 9; 1 Cor. 16: 13*

R: All that is true, noble, just, pure, practice all this: * and the God of peace will be with you!

V: Keep vigil, be firm in the faith, behave like men, be strong:

R: and the God of peace will be with you!

Second Reading. *Disc. 1*

Do not despise the poor as if they did not have any value.

From the discourse on “The duty of loving the poor” of St. Gregory of Nyssa, bishop.

Do not despise the poor as if they did not have any value. Consider who they are and you will know their dignity: they have dressed the person

of our Saviour.

He has kindly lavished it on them because, in the likeness of those men who stretch out towards their own assailants the image of the sovereign as a bulwark in order to check and to break the impetus, so also the poor subdue and sweeten those who ignore compassion and even persecute them. They are dispensers of gifts that we also wait for. They are the doorkeepers of the kingdom of heaven, who open the doors to the kind and to the good and close them to the wicked and to the cruel.

They are also violent accusers and excellent advocates. They accuse in fact and defend, not with discourses, but with their aspect itself, when they are examined by the eye of the Judge. They shout out that which is perpetrated against them and proclaim with great frankness and the efficacy of any auctioneer, in front of the one who scrutinizes the hearts and knows the thoughts of men and the secret impulses of the soul.

For them is described for us in all its particulars that tremendous judgement that you have often heard spoken of.

I see, in fact, the Son of Man coming from heaven, advancing on the air as if he was walking on the earth, surrounded by multitudes of angels. Then the throne of glory erected in a lofty place and the king seated on it. I see also all the families of men, the peoples, the nations that have lived down here, that have breathed this air and that have contemplated the light of this sun, in front of the tribunal, divided in two parts.

I hear that those who find themselves on the right are called lambs, and those who are on the left goats, because they receive their classification on the basis of their respective conduct of life. They hear the Judge who questions them and receives their justifications. I listen to what they answer to the King. Finally I perceive someone who is decorated because of his merits. To those who have been good and kind and have conducted a good life is granted a supreme and eternal rest in the heavenly kingdom; to the cruel and to the wicked instead is inflicted the punishment of fire for eternity. All these things are explained in the gospel with greatest care, as you well know.

I cannot believe that that judgement has been represented in front of our eyes, with terms that are so precise that it seems to be painted, for any other reason if not in order to induce us to learn in the end the exercise of beneficence and to embrace kindness.

It is this in fact which contains life. It is the mother of the poor, the master of riches, the good wet-nurse of the orphans, the protector of the old, the provision of the needy, the door for all the wretched: it takes care of all the ages and brings help in all the misfortunes and calamities.

Responsorial. *Lk. 6: 35, 36; Ps. 144: 8*

R: The Most High is kind to the ungrateful and the wicked. * Be therefore merciful, as your Father is merciful.

V: The Lord is patient and merciful, slow to anger and rich in grace.

R: Be therefore merciful, as your Father is merciful.

Gospel. *Lk. 6: 20 – 26*

Blessed are you, poor. Woe to you, rich.

From the Gospel of St. Luke.

And he lifted up his eyes on his disciples, and said: “Blessed are you poor, for yours is the kingdom of God. Blessed are you that hunger now, for you shall be satisfied. Blessed are you that weep now, for you shall laugh. Blessed are you when men hate you, and when they exclude you and revile you, and cast out your name as evil, on account of the Son of man! Rejoice in that day, and leap for joy, for behold, your reward is great in heaven; for so their fathers did to the prophets.

“But woe to you that are rich, for you have received your consolation. Woe to you that are full now, for you shall hunger. Woe to you that laugh now, for you shall mourn and weep. Woe to you, when all men speak well of you, for so their fathers did to the false prophets.

THURSDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *Hos. 2: 4, 8 – 25 (Vulg. 2:2,6 – 24)*

Israel, punished for its sins, will return to God.

From the prophet Hosea.

“Plead with your mother, plead -- for she is not my wife, and I am not her husband -- that she put away her harlotry from her face, and her adultery from between her breasts;

Therefore I will hedge up her way with thorns; and I will build a wall against her, so that she cannot find her paths. She shall pursue her lovers, but not overtake them; and she shall seek them, but shall not find them.

Then she shall say, ‘I will go and return to my first husband, for it was better with me then than now.’ And she did not know that it was I who gave her the grain, the wine, and the oil, and who lavished upon her silver and gold that they used for Ba'al.

Therefore I will take back my grain in its time, and my wine in its season; and I will take away my wool and my flax, which were to cover her nakedness.

Now I will uncover her lewdness in the sight of her lovers, and no one shall rescue her out of my hand. And I will put an end to all her mirth, her feasts, her new moons, her Sabbaths, and all her appointed feasts. And I will lay waste her vines and her fig trees, of which she said, ‘These are my hire, which my lovers have given me.’ I will make them a forest, and the beasts of the field shall devour them.

And I will punish her for the feast days of the Ba'als when she burned incense to them and decked herself with her ring and jewellery, and went after her lovers, and forgot me, says the LORD.

“Therefore, behold, I will allure her, and bring her into the wilderness, and speak tenderly to her. And there I will give her, her vineyards, and make the Valley of Achor a door of hope. And there she shall answer as in the days of her youth, as at the time when she came out of the land of Egypt.

“And in that day, says the LORD, you will call me, ‘My husband,’ and no longer will you call me, ‘My Ba'al.’ For I will remove the names of the

Ba'als from her mouth, and they shall be mentioned by name no more.

And I will make for you a covenant on that day with the beasts of the field, the birds of the air, and the creeping things of the ground; and I will abolish the bow, the sword, and war from the land; and I will make you lie down in safety.

And I will betroth you to me forever; I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love, and in mercy. I will betroth you to me in faithfulness; and you shall know the LORD. “And in that day, says the LORD, I will answer the heavens and they shall answer the earth; and the earth shall answer the grain, the wine, and the oil, and they shall answer Jezreel; and I will sow him for myself in the land. And I will have pity on Not pitied, and I will say to Not my people, ‘You are my people’; and he shall say ‘You are my God.’”

Responsorial. *Ap. 19: 7, 9; Hos. 2: 22*

R: The wedding of the Lamb has arrived; his bride is ready. * Blessed are those who are invited to the wedding of the Lamb!

V: I will betroth myself with you in faithfulness and you will know the Lord.

R: Blessed are those who are invited to the wedding of the Lamb!

Second Reading. *Red. A. strofa 38*

I will make you my bride forever.

From the “Spiritual Canticle” of St. John of the Cross, presbyter.

The soul that is united and transformed in God breathes God in God with the same divine breathing with which God, while in her, breathes her in himself. Such, I believe, was the meaning of Saint Paul when he said: “Because you are sons of God, God sent the Spirit of his Son into your hearts, crying in prayer to the Father,” which, in perfection is according to the manner described.

There is no need to wonder that the soul should be capable of a thing so high; for since God grants her the favour of attaining to being deiform

and united in the Most Holy Trinity, wherein she becomes God by participation, how is it incredible that she should perform her word of understanding, knowledge and love in the Trinity, together with it, like the Trinity itself, by a mode of participation, which God effects in the soul herself?

How this comes to pass cannot be known, nor is it possible to express it, save by describing how the Son of God obtained for us this high estate and granted us to be worthy of this high office, as Saint John says, of the power to become sons of God. And thus he prayed to the Father: "Father, I desire that they whom you have given me may be with me where I am, that they may see the glory which you gave me." That is to say, that they may work in us by participation the same work that I do by nature. He says further: "I pray not, Father, only for these that are present, but likewise for those who shall believe in me through their teaching, that they may be all one and the same thing; so that as you, Father, are in me and I am in you, even so they may be one and the same thing in us; and I have given them the glory which you have given me, that they may be one and the same thing, as we are one and the same thing; I in them, and you in me, that they may be perfect in one; that the world may know that you have sent me, and have loved them, as you have loved me."

The Father loves them by communicating to them the same love as to the Son, though not by communication of the divine nature as to the Son, but, as we have said, by unity and transformation of love. Neither is it to be understood here that the Son means to say to the Father that the saints are to be one thing in essence and nature, as are the Father and the Son; but rather that they may be so by the union of love, as are the Father and Son in unity of love. For this souls possess these same blessings by participation as he possesses by nature: for this reason they are truly gods by participation, equals of God and his companion.

Therefore Saint Peter said: "Grace and peace be complete and perfect in you in the knowledge of God and of Jesus Christ our Lord, according as all things are given to us of his divine virtue for life and godliness, through the knowledge of him who has called us with his own glory and virtue; whereby he has given to us many great and precious promises that by these things we may be made companions of the divine nature." Saint Peter indicates that the soul will have participation in God, performing in him, in company with him, the work of the Most Holy Trinity after the manner of

which we have spoken. And though this can be perfectly fulfilled only in the next life, nevertheless, in this life, when the estate of perfection is reached, a clear trace and taste of it are attained.

O souls created for these grandeurs and called to this! What are you doing? In what do you occupy yourselves? O wretched blindness of the sons of Adam, who are blind to so great a light and deaf to so clear a voice!

Responsorial. *Cfr. 1 Jn. 3: 1, 2*

R: What great love the Father has shown us: * we are called sons of God, and we really are!

V: We know that when he will be manifested, we will be similar to him, because we will see him as he really is:

R: we are called sons of God, and we really are!

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *2 Pt. 3: 1 – 10*

God is faithful to His promises.

From the Second Letter of St. Peter, apostle.

This is now the second letter that I have written to you, beloved, and in both of them I have aroused your sincere mind by way of reminder; that you should remember the predictions of the holy prophets and the commandment of the Lord and Saviour through your apostles.

First of all you must understand this, that scoffers will come in the last days with scoffing, following their own passions and saying, “Where is the promise of his coming? For ever since the fathers fell asleep, all things have continued as they were from the beginning of creation.” They deliberately ignore this fact, that by the word of God heavens existed long ago, and an earth formed out of water and by means of water, through which the world that then existed was deluged with water and perished.

But by the same word the heavens and earth that now exist have been stored up for fire, being kept until the Day of Judgement and destruction of ungodly men.

But do not ignore this one fact, beloved, that with the Lord one day is as a thousand years, and a thousand years as one day. The Lord is not slow

about his promise as some count slowness, but is forbearing toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance.

But the day of the Lord will come like a thief, and then the heavens will pass away with a loud noise, and the elements will be dissolved with fire, and the earth and the works that are upon it will be burned up.

Responsorial. *Mt. 24: 43-44; 2 Pet. 3: 10*

R: If the master of the house had known at what hour of the night the thief would come, he would have kept watch and would not have allowed him to break into the house. * Therefore you also be ready.

V: The day of the Lord will come like a thief; then the heavens with a roar will pass away.

R: Therefore you also be ready.

Second Reading. *C. 1*

Let us live in this world with soberness, justice and piety, in waiting for the manifestation of the glory of our great God.

From the “Exhortation to the pagans” of Clement of Alexandria.

The Lord is merciful, punishes, exhorts, admonishes, conserves, guards and, in compensation of the doctrine that he has taught us, he promises in the over abundance of his generosity the kingdom of heaven, without getting from us fruit other than our salvation. In fact the vice feeds on the ruin of men, while the truth, which is inborn in the things like a harmless bee, rejoices only in the salvation of men. You already possess the promise, you have all the love with which God loves the human race; participate now in the grace. But do not consider as “new” my song in the same way as an object or a house is said to be new. In fact he was before the “morning star” (2 Pet. 1: 19) and “in the beginning was the Word and the Word was with God and the Word was God” (Jn. 1: 1). In this sense we precede the creation of the world, in so much as we pre-exist in a certain way in God himself, because of our future creation. We are therefore rational creatures of the divine Word, that is of the divine Intelligence, and through him we can be called “first”, because “in the beginning was the Word”. And precisely as he existed before the foundation of the world, he was the divine beginning of all the things and still is; but since in these last times he has wanted to take the name of Christ, already considered in the past as holy, I call him new

Song. Therefore, this Word who is Christ was **not only the cause of our pre-existing**, but he grants us **also the possibility of living well**, and in these last times he has manifested himself to men as he who is the only one to be at the same time God and man. In fact, taught by him to live honestly, we are launched towards eternal life. Therefore, as that divine apostle of the Lord says: “The grace of God has appeared, the bearer of salvation for all men, who teaches us to repudiate wickedness and the worldly desires and to live with soberness, justice and piety in this world, awaiting the blessed hope and the manifestation of the glory of our great God and Saviour Jesus Christ” (Tit. 2: 11-13).

Therefore the new Song is that of the Word who was “in the beginning” (Jn. 1: 1). Now precisely the Saviour has appeared, who was already in the past; the Word that is, which was with God and through whom, all things have been made, has appeared in the garments of master; and he who as the creator of the world gave us life in the first creation, assuming the appearance of the master, has taught us the norms for living well in order to be then able to lavish on us as God, eternal life.

Responsorial. *Is. 30: 18; Heb. 9: 29*

R: The Lord waits to have mercy on you, for this he rises to have pity on you: because the Lord is a just God; * Blessed are those who hope in him.

V: Because he will appear to those who wait for him for their salvation.

R: Blessed are those who hope in him.

Gospel. Lk. 6: 27 – 38

Be merciful, as your Father is merciful.

From the Gospel of St. Luke.

“But I say to you that hear, Love your enemies, do good to those who hate you, bless those who curse you, pray for those who abuse you.

To him who strikes you on the cheek, offer the other also; and from him who takes away your coat do not withhold even your shirt. Give to every one who begs from you; and of him who takes away your goods do not ask them again. And as you wish that men would do to you, do so to them.

“If you love those who love you, what credit is that to you? For even sinners love those who love them. And if you do good to those who do good

to you, what credit is that to you? For even sinners do the same. And if you lend to those from whom you hope to receive, what credit is that to you? Even sinners lend to sinners, to receive as much again. But love your enemies, and do good, and lend, expecting nothing in return; and your reward will be great, and you will be sons of the Most High; for he is kind to the ungrateful and the selfish. Be merciful, even as your Father is merciful. "Judge not, and you will not be judged; condemn not, and you will not be condemned; forgive, and you will be forgiven; give, and it will be given to you; good measure, pressed down, shaken together, running over, will be put into your lap. For the measure you give will be the measure you get back."

FRIDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading *Hosea 4:1 – 10; 5:1 – 7*

The general correction of Israel also among the priests

Hear the word of the LORD, O people of Israel; for the LORD has a controversy with the inhabitants of the land. There is no faithfulness or kindness, and no knowledge of God in the land; there is swearing, lying, killing, stealing, and committing adultery; they break all bounds and murder follows murder. Therefore the land mourns, and all who dwell in it languish, and also the beasts of the field, and the birds of the air; and even the fish of the sea are taken away.

Yet let no one contend, and let none accuse, for with you is my contention, O priest. You shall stumble by day, the prophet also shall stumble with you by night; and I will destroy your mother. My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge; because you have rejected knowledge, I reject you from being a priest to me. And since you have forgotten the law of your God, I also will forget your children.

The more they increased, the more they sinned against me; I will change their glory into shame. They feed on the sin of my people; they are greedy for their iniquity. And it shall be like people, like priest; I will punish them for their ways, and requite them for their deeds. They shall eat, but not be satisfied; they shall play the harlot, but not multiply; because they have forsaken the LORD to cherish harlotry. Hear this, O priests! Give heed, O house of Israel! Hearken, O house of the king! For the judgement pertains to you; for you have been a snare at Mizpah, and a net spread upon Tabor. And they have made deep the pit of Shittim; but I will chastise all of them. I know Ephraim, and Israel is not hid from me; for now, O Ephraim, you have played the harlot, Israel is defiled. Their deeds do not permit them to return to their God. For the spirit of harlotry is within them, and they know not the LORD. The pride of Israel testifies to his face; Ephraim shall stumble in his guilt; Judah also shall stumble with them. With their flocks and herds they shall go to seek the LORD, but they will not find him; he has withdrawn from them. They have dealt faithlessly with the LORD; for they

have borne alien children. Now the new moon shall devour them with their fields.

Responsorial. *Ps. 13: 1, 2; Hos. 4: 1*

R: The fool thinks: “There is no God”. * From heaven the Lord looks down on men, to see if there exists a wise man, if there is one who searches for God.

V: The Lord opens proceedings with the inhabitants of the land: there is no sincerity, there is no love for the neighbour, or knowledge of God in the land.

R: From heaven the Lord looks down on men, to see if there exists a wise man, if there is one who searches for God.

Second Reading. *Nm. 14 – 15*

Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today and always.

From the “Dogmatic Letter against the Arians” of Ferrando, deacon.

Jesus Christ has become the guarantor of a better covenant. Besides, those became priests in a great number because death did not permit them to last long, he instead, because he remains forever, possesses a priesthood that does not set. Therefore he can save perfectly those who through him draw near to God, being always alive in order to intercede in their favour” (Heb. 7: 22-25).

Since therefore he has a priesthood that does not set he remains as priest forever: since he remains as priest, he remains man: since he remains as man, he appears minor. As a consequence, either the priesthood one day will have an end, or he will never cease to be minor. In fact the priest is always less than God of whom he is priest.

Yet the priest does two things: either he intercedes in order to be heard, or once heard he gives thanks; when he intercedes, he offers a sacrifice of imploring; when he gives thanks, a sacrifice of praise; interceding he presents the necessities of the sinners, giving thanks he enumerates the benefits mercifully granted to those who do penance; interceding he asks for forgiveness for the guilty, giving thanks he desires to share the joy of those who have been forgiven. So also Christ, having an eternal priesthood which death cannot put an end to like it does instead to the other priests, interceded for us offering on the cross the sacrifice of his own body, and he

intercedes still for everyone desiring that we ourselves become a pure oblation to God.

But when the divine mercy will be completely fulfilled in us, when the death will have been taken over in victory (cf. 1 Cor. 15: 55), when all our evils will have passed; when, satisfied with every good we will not sin any more, nor will we suffer, nor will we have to be subjected to the traps of the evil one, but we will reign in total peace and beatitude, then he will cease to intercede for us having by now nothing more to ask for; never however will he cease to give thanks for us.

As in fact now through our priest we ask for mercy, so also, when we will be constituted in that beatitude, through our priest we will offer the sacrifice of praise. Of this the Apostle who is witness says: “Through him we continuously offer a sacrifice of praise to God” (Heb. 13: 15).

Christ therefore will always be the priest through whom we will be able to offer the sacrifice of praise.

He will always be minor, since he is priest; yet, since he is Christ he is always one, he himself is priest and God, who, with the Father and the Holy Spirit is adored, blessed and glorified by the faithful. He intercedes and has compassion, gives thanks and gives the grace; and having taught his Church to keep this norm of offering sacrifice everyday, which is to raise up prayers for the sinners who are still on the earth as also for those who have already left this world, while for the martyrs they offer thanksgiving, so also he now, as long as we are unhappy, intercedes for us, while when he will have made us blessed, he will give thanks; in the one and in the other priestly office, the eternal priest therefore has a priesthood that does not set. The affirmation that we find in the Letter to the Hebrews is therefore true: “Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today and forever” (Heb 13: 8).

Responsorial *Heb 4:14, 16; Rom 3:25*

R: We have a great high priest, Jesus, Son of God. * Let us draw near therefore with complete trust to the throne of grace, in order to receive mercy and to be helped in the moment of need.

V: God has pre-established him to serve as an instrument of expiation through faith in his blood.

R: Let us draw near therefore with complete trust to the throne of grace, in order to receive mercy and to be helped in the moment of need.

CYCLE 2

First Reading *2 Pet 3:11 – 18*

The Lord is faithful, we await His coming

Since all these things are thus to be dissolved, what sort of persons ought you to be in lives of holiness and godliness, waiting for and hastening the coming of the day of God, because of which the heavens will be kindled and dissolved, and the elements will melt with fire! But according to his promise we wait for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells.

Therefore, beloved, since you wait for these, be zealous to be found by him without spot or blemish, and at peace. And count the forbearance of our Lord as salvation. So also our beloved brother Paul wrote to you according to the wisdom given him, speaking of this as he does in all his letters. There are some things in them hard to understand, which the ignorant and unstable twist to their own destruction, as they do the other scriptures. You therefore, beloved, knowing this beforehand, beware lest you be carried away with the error of lawless men and lose your own stability. But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ. To him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen.

Responsorial *Is 65:17, 18; Rev 21:5*

R: Behold, I create new heavens and a new earth; be glad and rejoice forever and ever for what I am creating. * Behold, I make everything new.

V: Because I now create Jerusalem 'Joy' and her people 'Gladness'.

R: Behold, I make everything new.

Second Reading *Hom. 1, 24*

The Son of man will come in the glory of His Father

From the "Homilies" of St. Bede the Venerable, presbyter

Our Lord and Redeemer has disposed that his elected arrive through the trials of this present life to the life that is free from every effort of the future beatitude. For this in his gospel he describes now the great efforts of the temporal battles, now the splendour of the eternal rewards, in a way that the

necessity of the battles reminds the faithful that in this life they must never ask for rest and, on the other hand, the sweetness of the future retribution will make the weight of the transitory evil lighter, for which they hope for an eternal recompense.

“The Son of Man will come in the glory of the Father with his angels and he will give to each one according to his actions” (Mt. 16: 27). In this text the Lord manifestly designs the day of the final judgement when, after having come once in humility and in degradation in order to be judged by the world, he will return in great majesty and power to judge the same world. When that is with the strictness of judge he will demand the perfection of the works of those to whom he will have first offered with abundant mercy the grace of his gifts. When, rendering to each one according to his works, he will lead the elected into the kingdom of his Father and he will cast out the reprobates with the devil into the eternal fire.

And justly it is said that the Son of man will come in the glory of his Father. The Son of man will come in the glory of God the Father, because he who in his nature of man is inferior to the Father, will appear in the divinity of a unique and same glory with the Father, true man and true God in everything.

With reason then the words that follow: “And he will render to each one according to his works” make the just rejoice and terrify the obstinate sinners: since through the intervention of the just Judge, those who now work for good and are afflicted by the unjust oppression of the wicked, not only will be freed from the violence of the wicked, but will receive also the reward of their justice and patience. Instead those who, living now in sin, consider inertia the patience of the Judge, repenting too late, will suffer a just sentence of eternal damnation. In accord with this evangelical sentence is the word of the psalmist: “Love and justice I want to sing, I want to sing hymns to you, Lord” (Ps. 100: 1). He says that he wants to sing first of love and then of justice because without doubt the Lord will demand more rigorously in his second coming the deposit that he has benevolently entrusted in the first. But the perverse, who despises the mercy offered to him by God, will be justly terrified by the justice of the discriminating Judge.

He however who, remembers with gratitude that he has received the grace of mercy, waits with joy for the decision of the justice and therefore sings spontaneously of love and justice to his Judge. In reality, since the

time of the universal judgement is uncertain for all as the hour of our own death is uncertain for each one of us, and the present trial could seem to be too long to those who ignored how just would have been the promised rest, the good Master wanted to manifest in anticipation the joys of the eternal promise to some of his disciples still living on the earth. This with the scope that the same disciples, and all those who later on would be able to listen to their word, would be able to bear more easily the present adversities, recalling more often to their minds the awaited grace of the future retribution. For this he continued: “Truly, truly I tell you: there are some present here who will not die, before they see the Son of man coming in his kingdom” (Mt 16:28).

Responsorial *Rev 22:12; Jer 17:10*

R: Behold, I am coming soon, * and I will bring with me my reward, to be given to each one according to his works.

V: I, the Lord, scrutinize the minds and test the hearts.

R: And I will bring with me my reward, to be given to each one according to his works.

Gospel *Lk 6:39 – 42*

Can one blind man lead another blind man?

He also told them a parable: “Can a blind man lead a blind man? Will they not both fall into a pit? A disciple is not above his teacher, but every one when he is fully taught will be like his teacher. Why do you see the speck that is in your brother's eye, but do not notice the log that is in your own eye? Or how can you say to your brother, ‘Brother, let me take out the speck that is in your eye’, when you yourself do not see the log that is in your own eye? You hypocrite, first take the log out of your own eye, and then you will see clearly to take out the speck that is in your brother's eye.

SATURDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading *Hos 5:15b – 7:2 (Vulg. 6:1 – 7:2)*

Insincere and vain conversion

“Come, let us return to the LORD; for he has torn, that he may heal us; he has stricken, and he will bind us up. After two days he will revive us; on the third day he will raise us up, that we may live before him. Let us know, let us press on to know the LORD; his going forth is sure as the dawn; he will come to us as the showers, as the spring rains that water the earth.” What shall I do with you, O Ephraim? What shall I do with you, O Judah?

Your love is like a morning cloud, like the dew that goes early away. Therefore I have hewn them by the prophets, I have slain them by the words of my mouth, and my judgement goes forth as the light. For I desire steadfast love and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God, rather than burnt offerings.

But at Adam they transgressed the covenant; there they dealt faithlessly with me. Gilead is a city of evildoers, tracked with blood. As robbers lie in wait for a man, so the priests are banded together; they murder on the way to Shechem, yes, they commit villainy. In the house of Israel I have seen a horrible thing; Ephraim's harlotry is there, Israel is defiled. For you also, O Judah, a harvest is appointed. When I would restore the fortunes of my people, when I would heal Israel, the corruption of Ephraim is revealed, and the wicked deeds of Samaria; for they deal falsely, the thief breaks in, and the bandits raid without.

But they do not consider that I remember all their evil works. Now their deeds encompass them, they are before my face.

Responsorial *Mt 9:13; Hos 6:4, 6*

R: Go and learn what is the meaning of: * Mercy I want and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God more than holocausts.

V: Your love is like the morning mist, like dew that disappears at dawn.

R: Mercy I want and not sacrifice, the knowledge of God more than holocausts.

Second Reading *Discourse 26*

All these things are fulfilled in Christ

From the “Discourses” of the blessed Martin of Lyon, monk

“Come, let us return to the Lord: he has torn us apart but he will cure us. He has beaten us and he will bind us up” (Hos. 6: 1). In this passage the faithful exhort each other to return to the Lord by doing good, they who had gone away from him by doing evil. Therefore, this is the voice of the faithful. As if they were to say: “Come, let us return to the Lord”; whom we have abandoned by sinning; because he himself has taken the initiative incarnating himself for us, “and he will cure us” changing our prison into freedom with his own passion. “He has beaten us” correcting us like a loving father “and he will bind up” our wounds: with the penance for sins. “After two days he will give us back our life” (Hos. 6: 2). All these things have been fulfilled in Christ; in fact, handed over on Thursday, crucified on Friday, he returned from the underworld rising at the dawn of Sunday. “And the third day he will make us rise up again and we will live in his presence” (Hos. 6: 2). With these words he shows us that Israel and Judah would have only one shepherd and king, David, that is Christ, who was born of the race of David according to the flesh, if they had believed in the same risen Lord.

“After two days he will give us back our life”, the two days that is that he lay in the sepulchre. “And the third day” rising from the dead “he will make us rise again” with him “and we will live” healed, vivified and risen – as much now as in the future – in his presence, while in his absence we lay dead; we will know him therefore in the majesty of the divinity, be it now imitating him, as well as afterwards, ascending into heaven, when we will know the Lord face to face. For which he said: “This is eternal life: that they know you, the one true God, and he whom you have sent, Jesus Christ” (Jn. 17: 3). The prophet, full of the Holy Spirit, said concerning the future that these things we already see realized in Christ.

For us the first day is that in which we are reborn through baptism; the second day is in the rest of the souls; the third in the universal resurrection. Besides that which the prophet says: “We will rise, and we will live in his presence” can be referred also to those who were held prisoners, and who will rise with him on the third day. And again the prophet adds “his coming is as sure as the dawn” (Hos. 6: 3). The dawn is the rising of the light, from which the darkness is put to flight. And speaking more openly: Come, let us

return to Christ, because, as the darkness of the night is put to flight by the rising of the dawn, so also the darkness of sins will be dissipated by the coming out of Christ from the nuptial bed of the virginal womb, and the appearance of the light of the truth.

Responsorial *Hos 6:2; 2 Cor 4:13, 14*

R: After two days he will give us back our lives, and the third day he will make us rise again * and we will live in his presence.

V: Animated by the Spirit of faith, we also believe that he who has resurrected the Lord Jesus, will also raise us with Jesus.

R: and we will live in his presence.

CYCLE 2

First Reading *Jude 1 – 8, 12 – 13, 17 – 25*

Denouncement of the impious; Exhortation to the faithful

Jude, a servant of Jesus Christ and brother of James, To those who are called, beloved in God the Father and kept for Jesus Christ: May mercy, peace, and love be multiplied to you.

Beloved, being very eager to write to you of our common salvation, I found it necessary to write appealing to you to contend for the faith which was once for all delivered to the saints. For admission has been secretly gained by some who long ago were designated for this condemnation, ungodly persons who pervert the grace of our God into licentiousness and deny our only Master and Lord, Jesus Christ.

Now I desire to remind you, though you were once for all fully informed, that he who saved a people out of the land of Egypt, afterward destroyed those who did not believe. And the angels that did not keep their own position but left their proper dwelling have been kept by him in eternal chains in the nether gloom until the judgement of the great day; just as Sodom and Gomor'rah and the surrounding cities, which likewise acted immorally and indulged in unnatural lust, serve as an example by undergoing a punishment of eternal fire.

Yet in like manner these men in their dreaming defile the flesh, reject authority, and revile the glorious ones. These are blemishes on your love

feasts, as they boldly carouse together, looking after themselves; waterless clouds, carried along by winds; fruitless trees in late autumn, twice dead, uprooted; wild waves of the sea, casting up the foam of their own shame; wandering stars for whom the nether gloom of darkness has been reserved for ever.

But you must remember, beloved, the predictions of the apostles of our Lord Jesus Christ; they said to you, “In the last time there will be scoffers, following their own ungodly passions.” It is these who set up divisions, worldly people, devoid of the Spirit. But you, beloved, build yourselves up on your most holy faith; pray in the Holy Spirit; keep yourselves in the love of God; wait for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ unto eternal life. And convince some, who doubt; save some, by snatching them out of the fire; on some have mercy with fear, hating even the garment spotted by the flesh.

Now to him who is able to keep you from falling and to present you without blemish before the presence of his glory with rejoicing, to the only God, our Saviour through Jesus Christ our Lord, be glory, majesty, dominion, and authority, before all time and now and for ever. Amen.

Responsorial *Cf. Tit 2:12-13; Heb 10:23*

R: Let us live in soberness, justice and piety in this world, * in waiting for the blessed hope and of the manifestation of the glory of our great God and Saviour Jesus Christ.

V: Let us try to stimulate one another in charity and in good works,

R: in waiting for the blessed hope and of the manifestation of the glory of our great God and Saviour Jesus Christ.

Second Reading *Discourse 256, 1. 2. 3*

Let us sing alleluia to God who is good, who frees us from all evil

From the “Discourses” of St. Augustine, bishop

Let us sing Alleluia here below while we are still anxious, so that we may sing it one day there above when we are freed from care. Why are we troubled here? Do you not expect me to be troubled when I read: ‘Is not a man’s life upon earth full of trial?’ Do you not expect me to be troubled when I hear the words: ‘ Watch and pray that you enter not into temptation?’ Do you not expect me to be troubled when temptation and trial abound that the Lord’s Prayer orders us to say when we pray: ‘Forgive us

our debts as we also forgive our debtors?’ Every day we pray, every day we are debtors. Do you think I can be free from care when every day I seek pardon for my sins and help in peril? When I have said for my past sins: ‘Forgive us our debts as we also forgive our debtors,’ I go on at once to add, because of perils still to come: ‘Lead us not into temptation,’ But how can the congregation be in security when it cries with me: ‘Deliver us from evil.’ And yet, brethren, in this evil plight of ours here below we must sing Alleluia to the good God who delivers us from evil.

Here, too, amidst the dangers and the trials we and others must sing Alleluia, ‘for God is faithful and he will not let you be tempted beyond your strength’ as Paul says. So then we must also sing here Alleluia. Man is still a sinner, but God is faithful. Scripture does not say, ‘He will not let you be tempted,’ but, ‘He will not let you be tempted beyond your strength, but with the temptation will also provide the way of escape, that you may be able to endure it. ‘You have entered into temptation, but God will also provide a way of escape that you may not perish in temptation. As the potter makes a vase, you are to be moulded by preaching; you are to be fired by tribulation. But when you enter into temptation, think of the way of escape; for God is faithful: ‘The Lord will keep your coming in and your going out.’

And so it is too, when this body has been made immortal and incorruptible, when every trial and temptation has passed away. For ‘the body indeed is dead’- and why? ‘Because of sin. But the spirit is life,’ as the apostle says, Why? ‘Because of righteousness’. Is it a dead body we give up? Indeed no, for hear what Paul says: ‘If the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, he who raised Christ from the dead will give life also to your mortal bodies.’ So now the body is of an animal nature, then it will be spiritual

How happy will be our shout of Alleluia there, how carefree, how secure from any adversary, where there is no enemy, where no friend perishes. There praise is offered to God, and here, too. But here it is by men who are anxious, there by men who will live forever. Here praise is offered in hope, there by men who enjoy the reality, here by men who are pilgrims on the way, there by men who have reached their own country.

So, brethren, now let us sing Alleluia, not in the enjoyment of heavenly rest, but to sweeten our toil. Sing as travellers sing along the road: but keep on walking. Solace your toil by singing- do not yield to idleness.

Sing but keep on walking. What do I mean by ‘walking’? I mean press on from good to better. The apostle says there are some who go from bad to worse. But if you press on, you keep on walking. Go forward then in virtue, in true faith and right conduct. Sing out-and keep on walking.

Responsorial *Cf. Tob 13:17, 18*

R: Your squares, Jerusalem, will be paved with pure gold, in you will resound hymns of joy, * and in all your houses they will sing: alleluia!

V: You will shine with a splendid light; and to you will come all the countries of the earth,

R: and in all your houses they will sing: alleluia!

Gospel *Lk 6:43 – 49*

Why do you call me Lord, Lord, and then do not do what I say

“For no good tree bears bad fruit, nor again does a bad tree bear good fruit; for each tree is known by its own fruit. For figs are not gathered from thorns, nor are grapes picked from a bramble bush. The good man out of the good treasure of his heart produces good, and the evil man out of his evil treasure produces evil; for out of the abundance of the heart his mouth speaks.

“Why do you call me ‘Lord, Lord’ and not do what I tell you? Every one who comes to me and hears my words and does them, I will show you what he is like: he is like a man building a house, who dug deep, and laid the foundation upon rock; and when a flood arose, the stream broke against that house, and could not shake it, because it had been well built. But he who hears and does not do them is like a man who built a house on the ground without a foundation; against which the stream broke, and immediately it fell, and the ruin of that house was great.”